

Families on the FAULTLINE

The unenviable distinction of leading in the number of family suicides reveals the stress on traditional social structures as Bihar makes the transition to modernity

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

Three-year-old Khushi is not sent to school to prevent anyone from telling her what happened to her parents. On February 26 this year, her father Abhay Singh, a Janata Dal (United) MLA, shot his wife Sony and infant daughter Rashi before killing himself. Khushi, Abhay's eldest daughter, survived since she was sleeping with her grandmother in another room. Abhay scribbled a suicide note in Hindi which said: "I am under great stress today. I am quitting my life." The deaths shocked relatives and friends who had no idea of the storm brewing in Abhay's mind.

The 33-year-old politician was in an election year where he was expected to play a key role beyond his constituency. He worked hard, and as his confidence and contacts grew, so did the confrontations with his wife, who perhaps wanted his undivided atten-

tion. Abhay, accustomed to having his way, cracked under the pressure.

Khushi misses her parents. She still smiles, rides her bicycle, and mingles with neighbourhood kids but often stares blankly at the wall, crying inconsolably at times. "We have not told her what happened. We are doing everything possible to ensure Khushi gets everything she needs. Almost," says her grandfather Narendra Singh, a senior minister in the Nitish Kumar Government.

Abhay's is not a lone case in Bihar, which has become the new dateline for family suicides. The National



MANISH BHANDARI

KAPIL (RIGHT) AND RAJKUMAR (SECOND FROM RIGHT)



INDERDEO MAHTO and KARI DEVI

Poverty, chronic illness and no support from their two sons, Rajkumar and Kapil (with their families, right), forced this septuagenarian couple from Khushalpur village in Gaya to consume poison in August last year. People were also reluctant to hire them due to their age. The labourer sons, who lived separately, today concede that they couldn't help. They, however, also blame their father for selling off paternal land to fuel his alcohol habit.